Monthly JBV / Research Policy Digest

Generated: 2026-09-11 21:21 **Coverage**: 2026-11 to 2027-01 | Journal of Business Venturing (3); Research Policy (14) **Total papers**: 17 (17 with abstract, 17 with PDF)

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Journal of Business Venturing

Volume 42, Issue 1 | Published 2027-01

1. Between mission pull and governance burden: Geographic distance and deal realisation in impact investing

Authors: Chukwuka Igboanua, Meike Siefkes, Simon J.D. Schillebeeckx, Henri Hakala

DOI: 10.1016/j.jbusvent.2026.106642 **Published**: 2027-01

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Entrepreneurial Finance, International Business, Social Entrepreneurship
- **Theories**: Transaction Cost Economics, Eclectic Paradigm (OLI), Location Logic

Abstract:

> Impact investing is widely expected to direct capital to locations where social and environmental challenges are most severe. Yet such opportunities are often found in places geographically distant from major pools of investment capital. We examine how geographic distance affects the realisation of impact investment deals and how host-country conditions alter that relationship. Integrating transaction cost economics with the location logic of the eclectic paradigm, we argue that impact investment decisions reflect the joint consideration of anticipated transaction value and governance costs. Distance raises the costs of screening, contracting, monitoring, and supporting ventures, while severe sustainability challenges can increase a location's mission-specific attractiveness by signaling greater unmet need and potential scope for additionality. By contrast, trade and investment risk increases transaction hazards that make distant deals harder to execute. We test these arguments using PitchBook data on 3126 impact deals closed in 2022–2023. We analyse 3606 realised investor–venture ties against matched

unrealised alternatives in a choice-based sampling design. Distance reduces the likelihood of deal realisation. Challenge severity modestly weakens the distance penalty for a subset of sampled dyads, whereas trade and investment risk strengthens it across most observations. These findings contribute to impact investing by explaining why severe unmet need does not automatically translate into realised investment relationships. They extend transaction cost reasoning in entrepreneurial finance by incorporating mission-adjusted transactional value. They refine international business location logic by distinguishing mission-specific locational attractiveness from host-country transaction hazard.

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2. Filling the legitimacy void: The value of sustainability orientation across investor segments in venture financing

Authors: Feilian Xia, James Thewissen, Paul P. Momtaz, Shuo Yan

DOI: 10.1016/j.jbusvent.2026.106641 **Published**: 2027-01

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Entrepreneurial Finance, Sustainable Entrepreneurship
- **Theories**: Legitimacy Theory, Institutional Theory, Signaling Theory

Abstract:

When and why does sustainability attract entrepreneurial funding? Drawing on legitimacy theory, we argue that prior institutional backing segments ventures into distinct contexts in which public investors value sustainability orientation differently. Without such backing, sustainability can compensate for missing commercial validation by providing an alternative source of moral legitimacy. When institutional backing already certifies pragmatic legitimacy, sustainability may conflict with return-oriented expectations. Examining 2222 token-based crowdfunding campaigns, we find that sustainability orientation is positively associated with funding among non-backed ventures but negatively associated with funding among institutionally backed ventures. Consistent with this segmented valuation logic, non-backed ventures display stronger sustainability orientation. An LLM-based decomposition shows no statistically significant difference between the extent to which substantive and symbolic sustainability attenuate the funding disadvantage of non-backed ventures; their greater sustainability orientation is most clearly concentrated in symbolic social content. Our findings position sustainability not as a universally beneficial cue, but as a compensatory source of legitimacy whose value depends on what other types of legitimacy ventures already possess.

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Volume 41, Issue 6 | Published 2026-11

1. More than money: The symbolic role of stock options in tech worker attraction by technology startups

Authors: Di Tong, Haifeng Wang

DOI: 10.1016/j.jbusvent.2026.106640 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Entrepreneurship, Human Resource Management, Organizational Behavior
- **Theories**: Signaling Theory, Symbolic Management, Sensemaking

Abstract:

The survival and growth of early-stage technology startups depend heavily on their ability to attract tech workers. It is popular for startups to offer stock options to rank-and-file tech workers, a practice rooted in the financial view that the financial prospects associated with these offerings help attract employees. Yet, recent research suggests tech workers often lack the

> knowledge necessary to properly evaluate stock options, casting doubt on this justification. To this end, we conducted a series of experiments to examine whether, and why, startup stock options may attract tech workers. We find a strong employee attraction effect for startups that offer stock options, which however is only partially driven by financial considerations. A more important driver appears to be tech workers' inference about a startup's unobservable qualities, particularly how it treats employees. While tech workers are aware of stock options' financial implications, they make financially calculated decisions only when explicitly prompted to do so. Recognizing that the financial view has limited applicability, our study highlights the importance of a symbolic approach to understanding stock options in startup recruiting. Our study contributes to the literature on startup recruiting and stock options by offering a more nuanced understanding of how tech workers make sense of stock option offerings and by highlighting the importance of a symbolic view alongside the prevailing financial view.

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Research Policy

Volume 55, Issue 10 | Published 2026-12

1. A cord of three strands: Industry-university-research collaboration and corporate ESG performance

Authors: Wanyi Chen, Ying Wang, Hao Ren

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105607 **Published**: 2026-12

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Corporate Sustainability, Innovation Management, Strategic Management
- **Theories**: Boundary Spanning Theory, Triple Helix Model, Resource-Based View, Stakeholder Theory

Abstract:

> Collaborative innovation equips firms with knowledge and resources aimed at competitiveness, but whether these also improve corporate environmental, social, and governance (ESG) performance is far from obvious. We examine industry-university-research (IUR) collaboration, that is, collaboration among industry, universities, and research institutes, a tripartite arrangement central to China's innovation system in which research institutes form a distinct third actor. Using a sample of Chinese A-share listed firms from 2009 to 2024, we find that IUR collaboration improves corporate ESG performance. The effect is economically meaningful: a one-standard-deviation increase in IUR is associated with an increase in ESG performance equivalent to 1.2% of its mean, and with increases of 4.8%, 2.1%, and 0.2% in the environmental, social, and governance dimensions, respectively. Adopting a boundary-spanning perspective, we show that the effect operates through three mechanisms, each tied to one ESG dimension: knowledge spillover that raises green awareness, resource integration that expands relational networks, and normative diffusion that strengthens human capital. The effect is stronger under high economic policy uncertainty, intense market competition, and advanced digital transformation, indicating that the value of boundary spanning is contingent on firms' external environment and internal capabilities. This study extends collaborative-innovation research from bilateral university-industry relationships to tripartite IUR collaboration in the Chinese context. It shifts the innovation-ESG literature from internally generated innovation to externally sourced, multi-party collaboration. It advances boundary-spanning theory by specifying when such collaboration improves sustainability performance. These findings offer guidance for policymakers and firms integrating collaborative innovation with sustainability goals.

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2. A note on the changing appropriability conditions and technological opportunities for innovation in Japan; 1994–2020

Authors: Akiya Nagata, Akira Goto

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105608 **Published**: 2026-12

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Innovation Economics, Strategic Management, National Innovation Systems
- **Theories**: Appropriability Theory, Technological Opportunity, National Innovation Systems

Abstract:

> We report findings obtained by comparing two innovation surveys in Japan conducted in 1994 and 2020. A comparison of statistical means at two points in time, controlling for firm size and industry as covariates, reveals that the following three changes have occurred for appropriabilities and technological opportunities of innovation during the past quarter-century. First, the effectiveness of almost all the mechanisms by which firms' appropriate profits from innovation declined. Second, the imitation lag has lengthened considerably. Third, while universities and government research institutes have become more important sources of technological information, internal sources and competitors have become less important. These results suggest that Japan's innovation system has undergone a fundamental transformation between the two time points.

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3. Immigration and firm innovation: Evidence from Finnish manufacturing

Authors: Terhi Maczulskij

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105603 **Published**: 2026-12

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Economics of Innovation, Labor Economics, Innovation Management, Human Capital
- **Theories**: Human Capital Theory, Knowledge Spillover Theory, Resource-Based View

Abstract:

> This study examines the relationship between immigration and firm-level innovation in the Finnish manufacturing sector. The analysis exploits unique matched data linking employees' immigration status with firm-level patenting, process and product innovation activities, and innovation inputs. To address the potential endogeneity of firms' immigrant employment, a newly developed instrumental variables approach is applied, using the predicted historical geographic distribution of immigrants as an instrument. The results show that immigrant employment positively affects firms' patenting activity and the number of R&D workers, with these effects being statistically significant only among more productive firms. Furthermore, firms with a higher concentration of non-native employees exhibit stronger immigration-innovation effects, suggesting that the mechanisms linking immigration and innovation may depend on the scale and stage of immigration. Finally, the study finds that immigration enhances firm growth and boosts native employment.

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4. Stronger patent law increases the allocation of resources to external relative to internal R&D: Empirical evidence

Authors: Yun Hou, Xi Xiong, I.P.L. Png

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105601 **Published**: 2026-12

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Innovation Management, Economics of Innovation, Intellectual Property Rights, Strategic Management
- **Theories**: Property Rights Theory, Transaction Cost Economics, Resource Allocation Theory

Abstract:

> How should a technology firm adjust resource allocation between external and internal R&D in response to stronger patent protection? External R&D provides the firm with another channel of earnings to mitigate diminishing returns to internal R&D, but yields the firm only a fraction of the additional profit generated. Theoretically, if the marginal return to external R&D diminishes more slowly than the marginal return to internal R&D, the firm should increase external R&D proportionately more than internal R&D. Exploiting regional differences in the strengthening of patent protection due to the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Federal Circuit (CAFC), we find that the CAFC was associated with 35 percent more external R&D vis-à-vis 20 percent more internal R&D. The difference was more pronounced among firms more specialized in technology and in industries where patents were less effective.

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Volume 55, Issue 9 | Published 2026-11

1. Burning bridges or bridging divides: Geopolitics and collaboration in research and innovation

Authors: Shreyas Gadgin Matha, Matte Hartog, Christian Chacua, Pierre-Alexandre Balland, Ricardo Hausmann, Muhammed Ali Yıldırım

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105580 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Science Policy, International Business, Geopolitics
- **Theories**: Gravity Model of International Trade, Technology Sovereignty

Abstract:

> This paper analyzes the association between geopolitical alignment and international research and innovation collaborations using data spanning 2000–2023. Using ideal point distance measures derived from UN General Assembly voting patterns, we find that increases in geopolitical distance are associated with reductions in international collaborations. A one-unit increase in geopolitical distance (roughly the distance between a median country pair) over three years is associated with a 3.1% reduction in collaborations in scientific publications (0.8% per standard deviation). We also find that this relationship is asymmetric: worsening geopolitical relations are associated with reductions in collaborations in scientific publications that are roughly three times larger than the gains associated with equivalent improvements, suggesting that international research partnerships are easier to damage than to build. At the technology level, critical technologies exhibit approximately three times the expected level of international collaboration compared to other fields (conditional on country-pair effects), yet are also more sensitive to shifts in geopolitical alignment, raising concerns about technology sovereignty. At the same time, despite ongoing geopolitical tensions, overall collaboration patterns have not undergone substantial changes in recent years, suggesting resilience in international research and innovation networks.

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2. Citations in 280 characters: Is social media presence worth it for elite journals?

Authors: Philipp Lucas Wähler, Christos Kolympiris, Nicos Nicolaou

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105581 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Sociology of Science, Scientometrics, Innovation Studies
- **Theories**: Matthew Effect, Status Theory, Information Diffusion

Abstract:

> Is it worthwhile for elite journals to actively promote their articles through an official social media account? We address this question by leveraging the staggered adoption of Twitter by three top economics journals: the Journal of Political Economy, the Quarterly Journal of Economics, and the Review of Economics and Statistics, to compare citation counts for promoted versus non-promoted articles. We find that institutional promotion increases citations, primarily by exposing research to audiences beyond economics and thereby fostering interdisciplinarity. The effect is larger for high-status authors, and we find suggestive evidence that it operates partly through authors' own networks. The way articles are presented, such as through visual aids, may further amplify their impact. These results show that active institutional promotion can enhance research dissemination even for journals that already command the lion's share of academic attention. At the same time, because the gains accrue disproportionately to already-visible authors, they raise concerns about inequities in scholarly recognition.

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3. Data and methods for identifying artificial intelligence-related patents

Authors: Tianjun Wu, Chao Min, Waverly W. Ding, Guolong Wang, Kunpeng Zhang

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105599 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Innovation Studies, Scientometrics, Computational Social Science
- **Theories**: Patent Analysis, Positive-Unlabeled Learning, Machine Learning

Abstract:

> This paper evaluates existing approaches to identifying artificial intelligence (AI)-related patents and introduces a novel, scalable framework for improving classification performance. Motivated by growing reliance on patent data in innovation research, we assess widely used methods, including patent class-based approaches and the USPTO's Artificial Intelligence Patent Dataset (AIPD), with an independent, human-expert-annotated ground-truth dataset. We document substantial performance limitations in existing approaches, particularly in terms of precision and generalizability. To address these challenges, we develop a CPC-informed label-refinement framework inspired by positive-unlabeled (PU) learning to construct high-quality training data. Our approach integrates hierarchical patent classification with data-driven refinement procedures to reduce label noise and improve representativeness. Using this refined dataset, we train a range of machine learning, deep learning, and transformer-based models. Our results show that models trained within our framework significantly outperform existing methods, including AIPD, achieving improvements over AIPD in F1 scores of approximately 18–21% on the same benchmark dataset. These gains are primarily driven by enhanced precision with only a modest reduction in recall, highlighting the central role of training data quality in classification performance. We further demonstrate the empirical value of improved AI patent identification through two applications, showing that the release of ChatGPT increased both the market valuation of AI patents and firms' allocation of innovative effort toward AI technologies. To support future research, we release our training data, source code, and a novel dataset of patent-level predictions (AIPat), with ongoing updates to reflect the evolving nature of AI innovation.

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4. Farther apart, faltering partnerships? The impact of geographical separation on research collaboration

Authors: Xin Liu, Ka Lok Pang, Yiwei Li, Zhiya Zuo, Dan Tian, Jiang Li

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105604 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Geography of Innovation, Economics of Science, Sociology of Science
- **Theories**: Proximity Framework, Social Capital Theory

Abstract:

> While technological advancements have reduced barriers to remote collaboration, the extent to which geographical proximity still shapes research outcomes remains a critical yet underexplored question. This study examines how geographical separation, defined as the loss of city-level co-location following collaborator mobility, affects the performance of established research collaborations. Using a quasi-experimental design, we analyze changes in research outcomes among 16,505 scientist pairs following inter-city relocation (treatment group) relative to intra-city relocation (control group). Our findings reveal that geographical separation leads to significant declines in both collaborative productivity (co-authored publications) and scientific impact (citation counts), underscoring the persistent role of proximity in sustaining effective collaboration. We further document important heterogeneity: interdisciplinary collaborations are more resilient in maintaining publication output but experience larger declines in scientific impact; same-stage collaborations are more vulnerable than cross-stage collaborations; and the negative effect is stronger in geographically larger countries. These findings highlight the enduring importance of geographical proximity in maintaining effective research collaboration.

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5. Global market integration, national security salience, and new product development alliances in aircraft manufacturing

Authors: João Albino-Pimentel, Pierre Dussauge, Louis Mulotte, Elie Sung, Stephen Tallman

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105583 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Strategic Management, Innovation Management, International Business, Geopolitics
- **Theories**: Resource-Based View, Resource Dependence Theory

Abstract:

> We investigate how the global market integration of a firm's home country and the security salience of specific projects shape firms' propensity to form alliances during new product development. The Resource-Based View suggests that the development of technologically complex products often requires unique resources that may be unavailable domestically, driving firms to seek international partnerships. However, we propose that, in high-technology industries where national interests are at stake, alliances in the product development phase face unique constraints. They involve partner firms committing non-redeployable resources to a specific, well-defined product and to new assets and processes to manufacture it. Moreover, because this phase determines which specific features become available for commercial or military deployment, these alliances attract heightened scrutiny from governments, especially in security-sensitive projects. We thus propose that the well-established relationship between product complexity and alliance formation is negatively moderated by two major geopolitical factors: (i) the global market integration of the firm's home country and (ii) the national security salience of the project. Both conditions enable or enhance alternative pathways to resource access that reduce dependence on alliances. Using data on new aircraft development projects, we find support for our predictions. Our findings contribute to the understanding of how home-country global market integration and project national security salience shape firms' innovation strategies by affecting alliance formation decisions during product development.

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6. Minds and machines: Rethinking absorptive capacity in the age of artificial intelligence

Authors: Mattia Pedota

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105600 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Innovation Management, Organizational Learning, Information Systems
- **Theories**: Absorptive Capacity, Human-AI Collaboration, Organizational Learning Theory

Abstract:

> The absorptive capacity construct derives its functions, dimensions, and internal relationships from the implicit assumption that humans are the only learning agents underlying knowledge absorption. I posit that the emergence of artificial intelligence (AI) challenges this assumption and requires a re-examination of the construct. Through a theory-building abductive study combining conceptual mapping with qualitative interviews, this work investigates the complex relationship between AI and knowledge absorption. It theorizes new dimensions of absorptive capacity pertaining to AI-driven processes and analyzes the interactions between these new dimensions and the traditional facets of the construct. Ultimately, the paper seeks to reaffirm the importance of absorptive capacity in the age of AI and develop a nuanced understanding of AI's role in reshaping the construct's antecedents, mechanisms, and implications.

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7. Modeling innovation ecosystem dynamics through interacting reinforced Bernoulli processes

Authors: Giacomo Aletti, Irene Crimaldi, Andrea Ghiglietti, Federico Nutarelli

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105587 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Economics of Innovation, Innovation Studies, Scientometrics
- **Theories**: Cumulative Innovation, Knowledge Spillovers, Evolutionary Economics

Abstract:

> Innovation is cumulative and interdependent: successful inventions build on prior knowledge within technological fields and may also affect success across related ones. Yet these dimensions are often studied separately in the innovation literature. This paper asks whether patent success across technological categories can be represented within a single dynamic framework that jointly captures within-category reinforcement, cross-category spillovers, and a set of aggregate regularities observed in patent data. To address this question, we propose a model of interacting reinforced Bernoulli processes in which the probability of success in a given category depends on past successes both within that category and across other categories. The framework yields joint predictions for success probabilities, cumulative successes, relative success shares, and cross-category dependence. We implement the model using granted US patent families from GLOBAL PATSTAT (1980–2018), defining category-specific success through a cohort-normalized forward-citation index. The empirical analysis shows that successful innovations continue to accumulate, but less than proportionally to the growth in patent opportunities, while technological categories remain interdependent without becoming homogeneous. Under a mean-field restriction, the model-based inferential exercise points to a positive but non-maximal interaction across technological categories.

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8. R&D investment, technology adoption and productivity dynamics: An empirical study of the productivity dispersion in Canada

Authors: Jianmin Tang, Weimin Wang, Sadaf Yalinejad

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105602 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Economics of Innovation, Industrial Organization, Productivity Analysis
- **Theories**: Technology Diffusion, Firm Heterogeneity, Endogenous Growth Theory

Abstract:

> Firm productivity dispersion has widened across many OECD countries and is often interpreted as evidence of persistent divergence between frontier and laggard firms, reflecting weakened technology diffusion and growing structural rigidities. This

> study revisits that narrative using comprehensive Canadian microdata and shows that conclusions about productivity divergence depend on how frontier and laggard firms are defined. Consistent with the existing literature, annually selected frontier and laggard firms exhibit a widening productivity gap over time. However, when the same firms are followed as fixed cohorts, the analysis reveals substantial productivity convergence rather than divergence. This contrast reflects the highly dynamic nature of firm productivity: approximately 15% of lagging firms move into the middle or frontier groups within three years, while 37% of frontier firms no longer remain at the frontier over the same period. The study demonstrates that the widely documented productivity gap between frontier and laggard firms partly reflects changes in firm composition rather than persistent differences among fixed groups of firms. The study further shows that sustained investments in R&D and technology are consistently associated with productivity mobility and the ability to maintain frontier status, with such investments being more prevalent among firms that improve their productivity performance or remain at the productivity frontier. These findings have important implications for interpreting productivity dispersion and for designing policies aimed at fostering productivity growth.

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9. Risk and the discursive construction of quantum technologies in Australia: How geopolitical and economic threats are used in hyping emerging technologies

Authors: Gabriella Skoff, Jarryd Daymond, Steven Maguire

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105582 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Science and Technology Studies, Innovation Studies, Sociology of Technology
- **Theories**: Sociology of Expectations, Risk Society

Abstract:

> In this paper, we examine the role of hype in the discursive construction of emerging quantum technologies. Our findings reveal that, as these technologies transition from academia to industry, they are the object of 'hyping' in which the discourses of risk and responsibility figure prominently. We find that hype – a collective vision around which attention, excitement, and expectations escalate – emerges from a process of discursively constructing emerging technologies as risk management solutions to highly salient geopolitical and economic risks to state actors, while acknowledging that they may pose less salient, novel social risks to citizens and social groups within a state. We also find that the former construction overwhelms the latter, which has important implications for what actions associated with developing these emerging technologies are considered responsible. As a result, and building on the sociology of expectations, we develop a discursive model showing how hyping mobilizes risk and responsibility to shape the meanings attached to emerging technologies and, in turn, the expectations that form around them – with important implications for the direction and pace of technological development.

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10. Science under sanctions: The impact of the entity list on Chinese academic research

Authors: Xiaodie Pu, Xintong Wang, Di Tong, Alain Yee Loong Chong

DOI: 10.1016/j.respol.2026.105584 **Published**: 2026-11

Fields & Theories:

- **Fields**: Economics of Science, Science Policy, International Relations
- **Theories**: Social Network Theory, Resource Dependence Theory

Abstract:

> This study examines the effects of geopolitical tensions and technology-related sanctions on academic research, with a focus on the U.S. Entity List's inclusion of Chinese academic institutions. Using a comprehensive dataset of academic publications from the Open Academic Graph, we employ a stacked event study design to estimate the causal effects of the Entity List sanctions on

academic research productivity. Our findings reveal that Entity List sanctions reduce the quantity but improve the quality of research output among affected Chinese researchers. Mechanism analyses, supplemented by semi-structured interviews, show that these changes are driven by research diversification and collaboration network reconfiguration. Sanctioned researchers shift toward new topics and form partnerships with non-listed Chinese institutions, which serve as intermediaries that restore access to restricted resources and expose researchers to novel knowledge. Notably, we find no significant decline in collaboration with U.S.-based researchers, suggesting that sanctions reconfigure rather than sever international networks. Theoretically, this study extends the disruption-as-catalyst logic to geopolitically imposed resource constraints, showing that sanctions can trigger productive diversification. By demonstrating that sanctions affect research quantity and quality in opposing directions through specific behavioral mechanisms, this study also reconciles inconsistent findings in prior literature and advances our understanding of how geopolitical tensions reshape the global academic research landscape.

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